



The Bin Cleared, the Rail Didn't

A Quasi-Experimental Trial of Donation-Sorting Shift Quotas Against Shop-Floor Fault Rates

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Background

A charity shop's items-processed-per-shift tally is its main quality signal for donation sorting. Whether a faster tally tracks faster degradation on the shop floor has gone untested.

Aims

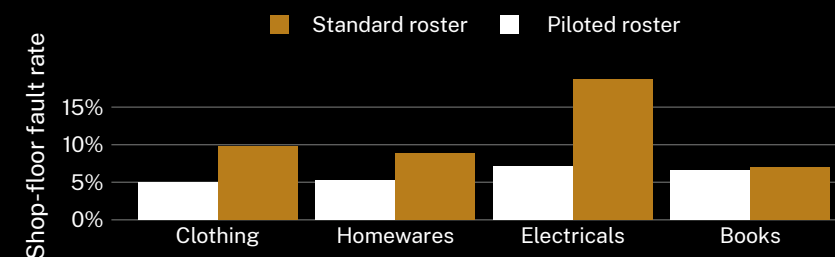
- Test whether a lower per-volunteer processing quota reduces the shop-floor fault rate.
- Compare fault detection across four donation categories under both shift structures.
- Establish whether the piloted roster outperforms the standard roster enough to justify permanent adoption.

Methods

- 3 charity shops · standard fast-throughput roster vs a piloted extended-shift, lower-quota roster · 9-month trial
- Weekly shop-floor spot-audits of 40 items per shop checked against sorting-log records (n = 1,080 items total)
- Category assignment (clothing, homewares, electricals, books) held constant across both roster conditions

Results

Results suggest the standard roster's faster tally comes at a measurable shop-floor cost: the piloted lower-quota shift roughly halved the fault rate (11.4% to 6.2%) even as its own tally fell 34% behind the standard roster's.



Shop-floor fault rate by donation category, standard vs piloted roster, aggregated across three charity shops, March-November 2026. Electricals shows the widest gap (18.7% vs 7.1%).

Discussion & conclusions

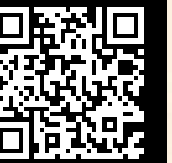
The tally that governs volunteer scheduling and the fault rate that governs resale value move in opposite directions under time pressure. Category effects vary sharply; a single shop-wide quota may be the wrong instrument regardless of its level. Next: a twelve-month multi-site rollout reporting the quota alongside the fault rate on the same board.

References

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Donation records de-identified at collection; no donor contact details retained.

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“The bin empties in half the time. The rail doesn't get any cleaner.”

Shop-floor fault rate: 11.4% under standard shift quotas vs 6.2% under the piloted lower-quota roster (n = 1,080 audited items, 9 months).